PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Isuzu Trooper (first generation)

1981–1991 · UBS · Trooper II · Bighorn · Jackaroo

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust first, everything else second**
  Check the rear cargo doors, their hinges and pins, the floors and the sills. Isuzu recalled 1984–87 trucks (92V093) because salt-belt corrosion in the rear-door hinges could let the doors close in a false latch, and a Curbside Classic reader summed up the rest: once the rear doors started to rust, it was game over.

- [ ] **Look at every wheel stud**
  Stripped or snapped wheel studs and galled lug nuts are among the most common owner complaints logged with NHTSA for 1988–91 Troopers, and Curbside Classic's owner broke them too. Make sure all 24 studs are present and the nuts thread on by hand.

- [ ] **Ask about the head and head gasket**
  NHTSA's complaint files for 1988 and 1989 Troopers include several cracked cylinder heads and repeated head-gasket failures, and a Curbside Classic reader lost his truck to 'the head gasket issue'. Look for a history of overheating, coolant in the oil and a radiator that hasn't been neglected.

- [ ] **Check that the recall work was done**
  1990–91 trucks were recalled for an oil-cooler hose that could touch the exhaust manifold and melt (90V166), and for automatic transmissions that could spill overfilled fluid onto the exhaust (90V167). On 1987–88 trucks (89V001), a heater bolt could rub through a fuel pipe. NHTSA's 1990–91 complaint files also include several under-hood fires.

- [ ] **Engage the hubs and the low range**
  Put it in 4WD high and low on loose ground. Auto-locking hubs should lock and unlock reliably, and the transfer case should shift without a fight. Many owners swap tired auto hubs for manual ones.

- [ ] **Know which engine you're getting**
  Early 1.95s and 2.3s are slow. The injected 2.6-liter four (1988–91) and the 2.8-liter GM V6 (1989–91) are the stronger engines, but NHTSA's 1988–89 complaint files include cracked heads, so the history matters more than the badge. US turbo-diesels from the mid-1980s are rare and were never sold in California.

- [ ] **Drive the automatic hard**
  A Curbside Classic reader's automatic failed at about 175,000 miles, and NHTSA's 1990–91 complaint files include several slipping, leaking or failed transmissions. A five-speed is the simpler buy.

- [ ] **Ask for the timing-belt receipt**
  The Isuzu four-cylinder petrol engines use a timing belt (the 2.3 switched from a chain to a Kevlar belt), so a truck with no record needs one before it goes anywhere remote.

YEARS TO KNOW

1990–1991	RECALL	Recalls for the oil-cooler hose (90V166) and automatic transmission overfill (90V167); NHTSA's owner complaints include under-hood fires and stripped wheel studs

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Rear-door hinge corrosion and false latching**
  1984–1987 · NHTSA 92V093
- ☐ **Heater bolt can rupture the fuel pipe**
  1987–1988 · NHTSA 89V001
- ☐ **Oil-cooler hose can melt on the exhaust manifold**
  1990–1991 · NHTSA 90V166
- ☐ **Overfilled automatic transmission can spill fluid on the exhaust**
  1990–1991 · NHTSA 90V167
- ☐ **Reese trailer-hitch receiver weld**
  1986–1991 · NHTSA 93E023

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Chassis codes by engine**
  Wikipedia lists UBS13 (1.95 L G200Z), UBS16 (2.3 L 4ZD1), UBS17 (2.6 L 4ZE1), UBS52 (2.2 L C223 / C223T diesel) and UBS55 (2.8 L 4JB1 diesel). The US V6 trucks use GM's 2.8 L pushrod engine.
- ☐ **Facelift**
  1984–86 trucks have the original front end; from 1987 the Trooper II has flush rectangular headlights and a new grille.
- ☐ **Trooper RS**
  The 1989-only US short-wheelbase two-door has a wheelbase of about 90 inches instead of 104, a 2.6 L four, 4.77:1 gears and 15 × 7 'snowflake' alloys.
- ☐ **Re-badges**
  Holden Jackaroo (Australia and New Zealand), Isuzu Bighorn and Subaru Bighorn (Japan), Chevrolet Trooper (Indonesia and South America) and Caribe 442 (Venezuela) are the same truck. SsangYong's Korando Family is licence-built with its own bodywork.
- ☐ **Bighorn Irmscher R**
  A limited run of 100 Japanese-market Bighorns with Irmscher graphics, a hood scoop, fender flares, Recaro seats and an Irmscher wheel, all cosmetic, with the 2.8 L intercooled turbo-diesel.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/trooper/trooper-1/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks